

horny at weddings", Basu ends his story, apocryphally, but of course we know by then (if we did not all along) that horniness has hardly anything ever to do with brides and grooms. It is a lesson that is borne aloft triumphantly by the stories that follow, in which sexiness finds its multiple sites of desire, deprivation and gratification in registers that range from the poetic to the fantastical, from the distressing, the uplifting, the wistfully melancholic to the raucously funny and the pensively touching.

Sonia Jabbar and Paromita Vohra, are very pleasant surprises in a collection that otherwise features a fair smattering of recognisable names, if not the heavyweights (perhaps thankfully). Jabbar offers a rollicking take on the sexual mores of a middle-class man in small town Uttar Pradesh, built up around the colourful, if predictable, understanding of masculinity as what burgeons beneath one's nightwear, apropos of the ultimate insult "Well, then you're not a man, you're a pajama." Vohra creates a kaleidoscope of visual and tactile sensations as she conjures up her story of a young woman on a film set who finds herself marooned on an island with a Bollywood star, in a beguiling time-travel fantasy.

Boldly experimental, Abeer Hosque's short piece on the female orgasm is startlingly innovative and vibrantly prismatic in its immense possibilities, not the least of which is a rich (feminine?) humour. In contrast, Jeet Thayil's unsentimental yet moving account of heroin addiction and two love-and-lust-less lives meeting momentarily but not memorably is chastening, thought-provoking ("...she didn't complain or turn away, but lay with me, breathing and solemn."). Parvati Sharma's reprise of Ismat Chughtai's "seminal" lesbian story, "The Quilt" is a rapturous romp amidst the bedclothes of sex and literature, seductively suggesting that pillow-talk of "the Quilt is not the Closet" variety can literally keep you coming all night. And have you begging for more, in fact.

Daringly enough, there is a recurrent motif of auto-eroticism in the stories, saluting what could rightfully be considered the most salubrious of sexual activities. But then masturbation—other than mental—remains, quaintly, more taboo in South Asia than any other kind of sexual activity, perhaps. Joshi himself brings up the rear in *Electric Feather*, in a gritty rumination on variations of female panties, nationalities and what they do (and don't) to a poor man "before he goes for his hand again". With *Electric Feather*, literary erotica comes of age in South Asian English fiction, not with a whimper but with a bang. Yes yes yes, as Savitabhabhi might have replied to Molly Bloom. ■

TOP 10

A monthly list of national bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG

FICTION

1. Sidney Sheldon's *Mistress of the Game*
Sidney Sheldon and Tilly Bagshaw
2. *Paths of Glory*
Jeffrey Archer, Macmillan
3. *The Winner Stands Alone*
Paulo Coelho, HarperCollins
4. *The 3 Mistakes of My Life*
Chetan Bhagat, Rupa
5. *The White Tiger*
Aravind Adiga, HarperCollins

NON-FICTION

1. *Stay Hungry Stay Foolish*
Rashmi Bansal, CIE, IIM-Ahmedabad
2. *Don't Lose Your Mind, Lose Your Weight*
Rujuta Diwekar, Random House
3. *Imagining India: Ideas for the New Century*
Nandan Nilekani, Allen Lane
4. *Jinnah: India, Partition, Independence*
Jaswant Singh, Rupa
5. *The Idea of Justice*
Amartya Sen, Allen Lane

OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

FICTION

6. *Of Course I Love You... Till I Find Someone Better*
Durjoy Datta and Maanvi Ahuja, Srishti
9. *Almost Single*
Advaita Kala, HarperCollins
10. *Secrets & Lies*
Jaishree Misra, HarperCollins

NON-FICTION

6. *A Better India A Better World*
N.R. Narayana Murthy, Allen Lane
10. *BPO-Sutra: True Stories from Inside India's BPOs & Call Centres*
Sudhindra Mokhasi, Rupa
11. *The Laws of the Spirit World*
Khorshed Bhavnagri, Jaico

Participating bookshops: Delhi: Om Book Shop, Teksons, Land Mark, Crossword; Mumbai: Oxford, Shah Book Stall, Modern Book Shop; Bangalore: Gangarams, Land Mark; Hyderabad: Walden Book Link, The Book Point; Kolkata: Oxford Books, Modern Book Depot, Family Book Shop; Chennai: Land Mark

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